

HOW TO LEARN DONNA LEE!

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #146

Donna Lee, the Charlie Parker/Miles Davis composition is widely considered to be one of those "crazy hard" jazz tunes. Up there with Giant Steps and a few others, we are supposed to be scared of it. We are supposed to be in awe of it, and we imagine that it is OK if we put it off for 10 years and don't learn it now. To that I say "rubbish!" It's just a song, and it is actually a simpler song than many.

All songs are built of a variety of musical elements, and Donna Lee is built up of the same elements as every other song. Learn the elements and you've learned the song!

Melody (intricate, lots of notes)	How to learn it?	Repetition, Looping
Tempo (fast!)	How to learn it?	Play it SLOW, Focus on technique
Articulation (complicated?)	How to learn it?	Mostly legato, bebop articulation
Harmony (tricky?)	How to learn it?	Break it down to basics

- 1) Dominant II chords 2) Dominant VI chords 3) Two measure ii-V's
4) One measure ii-V's 5) Minor ii-V's

Donna Lee (first half)

Staff 1: $A\flat maj7$ $F7$ (#2) $B\flat7$ (#1) $B\flat7$

Staff 2: $B\flat m7$ (#3) $E\flat7$ $A\flat maj7$ $E\flat m7$ (#4) $A\flat7$

Staff 3: $D\flat maj7$ $G\flat7$ $A\flat maj7$ $F7$ (#2)

Staff 4: $B\flat7$ (#1) $B\flat7$ $B\flat m7$ (#3) $E\flat7$